India. Her husband Ramesh disappeared five years ago, and rumour has it that she killed him. Spoiler: she didn't. But being reviled as the local *churail* has its advantages. No one messes with her; village busybodies give her a wide berth; men avoid her. Geeta can't complain—she loves being an independent woman, with a thriving business selling her handmade jewellery. Also, Phoolan Devi is her hero.

When a fellow villager asks her to help with husband-disposal services, Geeta's carefully curated world starts to unravel. Her efforts to nip this nonsense in the bud blows up, instead, into a Bollywood-worthy chain of events. Complete with a bumbling crime lord, corrupt policemen, an irrepressible pup, a secret romance-of-sorts, and the rekindling of lost friendships.

Shroff's light touch belies the heavy truths that lie at the centre of this novel. The heaviest is how the family is a site of extreme cruelty for women. Geeta's fellow women—whether fictional or in reality—are often both breadwinners and homemakers, trapped by patriarchy's unkindest cut—marriage. Though easier to spot in the conservative societies of South Asia, it holds true everywhere in the world.

Which is what makes Shroff's motives for basing her story in a remote village in India morally suspect. As an American of Indian origin, the author's connection to the setting and characters of her story was a childhood trip to a remote village in Gujarat where her father was involved in financing a women's micro-credit group. The women and their stories stayed with Shroff over the years, and finally took shape in some of the characters in *The Bandit Queens*.

However, this could easily have been a story set elsewhere in India or the world. One can't help wonder if the rural setting plays a role in manufacturing an exotic other, for a western audience. At the very least, there is an element of classism here, a need to separate the "us" from "them", to emphasise this doesn't happen to people like us.

I can still imagine a Geeta actually making it as a single businesswoman in a deeply parochial village, or a Phoolan Devi-inspired band of women in a remote rural outcrop doing away with their violent menfolk. *The Bandit Queens*'s most unforgivable sin is that the village women speak in yuppy Americanese. It doesn't ring true in its rural setting, but that shouldn't keep you from enjoying a rollicking story. ■

Payal Dhar

THE BANDIT QUEENS
by Parini Shroff
HARPERCOLLINS
₹499; 352 pages



The first half of Anupama Mohan's debut novel *Where Mayflies Live Forever* is a series of eyewitness interviews conducted by a police officer, an ACP called Asha Peter, who we only meet after several 'POV chapters' centring other characters are done and dusted. ACP Peter (who, as per genre trappings, is a divorced and world-weary maverick) is investigating the murder of Senganoor Adhiban, a political bigwig in the small town of Sittanavasal, Tamil Nadu. We learn that Adhiban has recently been decapitated. The head is missing, as is the chief suspect Veni, a young woman who teaches geography at the local school and who was gangraped by Adhiban and his cronies four years ago.

The beauty of *Where Mayflies Live Forever* lies in the fact that during the course of these testimonies, as we learn more about Veni, the novel unfurls its true nature—a sociologically adept character study about the contrasting ways in which we bring up boys and girls, respectively.

Veni, irreverent nature-lover, knowledgeable midwife, masseur to babies and new mothers, possessor of a singularly beautiful head of hair. By all accounts, she is an unusually sensitive, kind person with a lot of goodwill in Sittanavasal (at least before she is 'spoiled', the novel's damning metaphor for rape). How could she decapitate a man in cold blood and then—allegedly—burn off her own hair and vanish into thin air?

Mohan has a poet's grasp of the unusual adjective, the devastating, paragraph-ending one-liner

To Mohan's credit, once the answers start to trickle in, we realise that the metaphysical is just as important as the forensic; 'Where is Veni' takes a backseat to 'Who is Veni?'. By the time ACP Peter has a grasp on the fundamentals of the case, the reader is more invested in the philosophical resolution than the criminal one. The 'POV chapters' narrated by Veni's family and friends effectively set an atmospheric, idiosyncratic tenor for the novel and Mohan has a poet's grasp of the unusual adjective, the devastating, paragraph-ending one-liner.

In the chapter where Peter is given the narrator's reins, she reflects upon the fact that a solid homicide investigation "(...) was not always about cause and effect, it required critical imagination...even a flight or two of inspired fancy, all the while coordinating, calibrating and shifting facts, premises, conclusions like a card-sharper moves his playing deck before the watchful eyes of his patrons: if you missed a trick, the game was lost." Mohan may well have been talking about her own modus operandi while writing her novel, a work of fiction that 'performs' genre rather than embracing it un-ironically. And what a marvellous performance it is, too. ■

Aditya Mani Jha